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Measuring Schoolchildren's Wellbeing: A Review of Instruments and Their Psychometric Properties

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ABSTRACT

Schoolchildren's wellbeing is increasingly regarded as an educational outcome in its own right alongside academic achievement, and many education systems include it in their monitoring programmes. However, wellbeing is defined in different ways, and the instruments used to measure it vary considerably in structure, length and quality. This review analyses 38 instruments for measuring the subjective wellbeing of children and adolescents aged 8–18, described in 116 publications from 2000–2025. For each instrument, the theoretical basis, measured components, age range, availability of a Russian-language version and psychometric properties were assessed according to the COSMIN standard: reliability, structural validity, measurement invariance and responsiveness. Most instruments draw on a hedonic or eudaimonic model of wellbeing or a combination of the two, and school wellbeing is identified as a separate component in only a third of them. Internal consistency is acceptable for the vast majority of scales, but measurement invariance across age groups and language versions has been tested for only 11 instruments. Russian-language adaptations are available for nine instruments, but their psychometric properties have been studied incompletely. Recommendations for selecting instruments for school monitoring are formulated and directions for further adaptation are outlined.

Keywords: student wellbeing; psychometrics; measurement instruments; education monitoring; COSMIN

Измерение благополучия школьников: обзор инструментов и их психометрических свойств

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АННОТАЦИЯ

Благополучие школьников всё чаще рассматривается как самостоятельный результат образования наряду с академическими достижениями, и многие системы образования включают его в программы мониторинга. Вместе с тем понятие благополучия определяется по-разному, а инструменты его измерения существенно различаются по структуре, длине и качеству. В обзоре проанализированы 38 инструментов измерения субъективного благополучия детей и подростков в возрасте 8–18 лет, описанных в 116 публикациях за 2000–2025 гг. Для каждого инструмента оценены теоретическая основа, измеряемые компоненты, возрастной диапазон, доступность русскоязычной версии и психометрические характеристики по стандарту COSMIN: надёжность, структурная валидность, инвариантность измерения и чувствительность к изменениям. Показано, что большинство инструментов опираются на гедонистическую или эвдемоническую модель благополучия либо на их сочетание, а школьное благополучие как отдельный компонент выделяется лишь в трети из них. Надёжность внутренней согласованности приемлема для подавляющего большинства шкал, однако инвариантность измерения между возрастными группами и языковыми версиями проверялась лишь для 11 инструментов. Русскоязычные адаптации доступны для девяти инструментов, но их психометрические свойства изучены неполно. Сформулированы рекомендации по выбору инструментов для школьного мониторинга и намечены направления дальнейшей адаптации.

Ключевые слова: благополучие школьников; психометрика; инструменты измерения; мониторинг образования; COSMIN

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1 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, an increasing number of education systems have come to regard student wellbeing as a goal comparable in importance to academic outcomes. International studies include questions on subjective wellbeing, and national and regional monitoring systems are introducing their own indicators.

The diversity of instruments makes it difficult to choose among them and to compare results. The aim of this review is to systematise existing instruments for measuring the subjective wellbeing of schoolchildren and to assess their psychometric quality from the standpoint of their applicability in Russian schools.

2 MATERIALS AND METHODS

The search was conducted in bibliographic databases on psychology and education for 2000–2025. Publications were included that describe the development or testing of the psychometric properties of a self-report instrument of subjective wellbeing for children and adolescents aged 8–18 years. Of the 1,420 records, 116 publications describing 38 instruments were selected.

The methodological quality of the studies and the psychometric properties were assessed independently by two experts using the COSMIN checklist. For each property, the overall rating was given as “sufficient”, “insufficient” or “indeterminate”.

3 RESULTS

The distribution of instruments by theoretical basis and by the presence of a separate school wellbeing component is presented in Table 1. Most instruments are multidimensional and include from three to seven subscales.

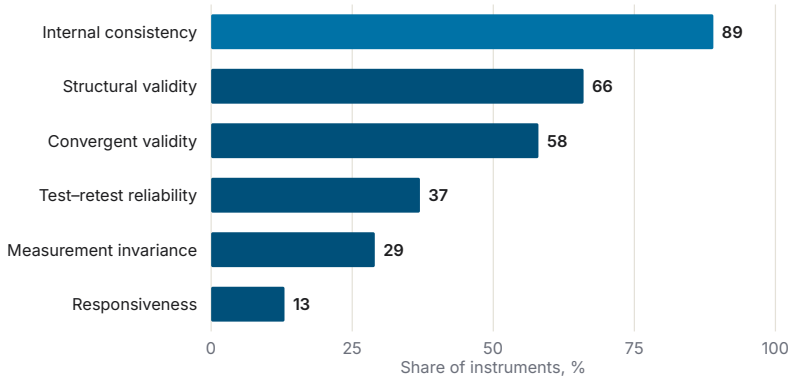


Fig. 1. Share of instruments with sufficient evidence by psychometric property, % (n = 38)

The share of instruments with sufficient evidence for each psychometric property is shown in Fig. 1. Reliability and structural validity have been studied most thoroughly, and responsiveness and measurement invariance least.

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Table 1. Characteristics of the instruments reviewed

Theoretical basis	Number of instruments	With a school wellbeing scale	Russian-language version
Hedonic	12	3	4
Eudaimonic	9	3	2
Integrative	13	6	3
Other / atheoretical	4	1	0
Total	38	13	9

4 DISCUSSION

The lack of evidence on measurement invariance is the main limitation on the use of the instruments in monitoring, where results are compared across age groups, schools and regions. Without such testing, differences in scores may reflect differences in how the questions are understood rather than real differences in wellbeing.

For Russian schools, full validation of the existing Russian-language versions, including testing of invariance across primary, lower secondary and upper secondary school, is particularly pressing.

5 CONCLUSION

Existing instruments for measuring schoolchildren's wellbeing are diverse, but their psychometric properties have been studied unevenly. For monitoring purposes, it is recommended to use instruments with confirmed measurement invariance and to continue the validation of the Russian-language versions.

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